Reconstruction Plans, 1863–1864

Lincoln's Ten Percent Plan (Dec. 8, 1863) & the Wade-Davis Bill (July 1864)

Source: Avalon Project, avalon.law.yale.edu/19th_century/lincoln3.asp; Library of Congress.

Even before the Civil War ended, Lincoln and Congress disagreed sharply over how to readmit Confederate states. Lincoln's Proclamation of Amnesty and Reconstruction offered lenient terms — any state could rejoin the Union once 10% of its 1860 voters swore loyalty. Radical Republicans in Congress passed the much harsher Wade-Davis Bill, requiring 50% loyalty oaths and excluding former Confederates from the constitutional conventions. Lincoln pocket-vetoed Wade-Davis. The dispute previewed the bigger battle between Andrew Johnson and Congress after Lincoln's death.

Connect: The debate between Lincoln and Congress over Reconstruction is really a debate about who won the war — the executive or the legislature. Which branch had more power during the actual war?

Key Passages

Lincoln's Ten Percent Plan

> Whenever … a number of persons, not less than one-tenth in number of the votes cast in such State at the Presidential election of the year of our Lord one thousand eight hundred and sixty … shall have taken the oath aforesaid, and … shall have established a State government … such shall be recognized as the true government of the State.

Wade-Davis Bill (majority loyalty)

> Whenever the people of any such State, having at least a majority of the white male citizens, … shall, by their delegates, … have framed a constitution … such constitution, when ratified, shall be recognized as the constitution of the State.

Wade-Davis Manifesto (response to Lincoln's veto)

> The President … must understand that our support is of a cause and not of a man … that the authority of Congress is paramount and must be respected … and if he wishes our support, he must confine himself to his executive duties — to obey and execute, not make the laws — to suppress by arms armed rebellion, and leave political reorganization to Congress.

HAPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HAPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Context *What was happening when this was written?*	The Civil War was not yet won (1863-64), but Union forces held parts of the South; Lincoln and Congress argued over who controlled Reconstruction.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Ten Percent Plan: Southern whites and Confederates who might return to loyalty. Wade-Davis Bill: Congress and Unionists demanding tougher terms.
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Lincoln, who wanted quick, lenient reunion, versus Radical Republicans (Wade and Davis) who wanted to punish the South; freedpeople had little voice in either plan.

HAPP Element	Your Analysis
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. Contextualization (DBQ/LEQ, 1 pt): Place these two plans in the broader 1863–1877 Reconstruction debate.

2. Identify ONE provision that shows how differently Lincoln and Congress understood the war.

3. Whose plan was more 'just' to the freedpeople? Defend your view.